

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

ATVs are swarming Pembroke Township. Residents say a rare ecosystem and the community are helpless



An ATV drives through a sand dune on private property Dec. 15 in Hopkins Park. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Downward trend in homicides continues

City had fewer than 600 slayings, but officials are not celebrating just yet

By Sam Charles
Chicago Tribune

Despite recording more than 570 homicides in 2024, Chicago actually saw signs of improvement, with that total marking the third consecutive year the city recorded fewer killings than the one prior.

In fact, 2024 was the first year since the COVID-19 pandemic that the city had fewer than 600 slayings before the turn of the calendar. The official figure was 571 just before Christmas, but no one is claiming victory.

Chicago saw a 7% overall decrease in murders and nonfatal shootings in 2024, a year hallmarked by the Democratic National Convention and another annual uptick in summer gun violence. But each of CPD's five patrol areas — clusters of districts that blanket the whole city — saw a reduction in killings year-over-year, city data show.

"It's not even just the homicides, but the number of people who have been traumatized by gun violence," CPD Superintendent Larry Snelling, entering his second full year as head of the department, recently told the Tribune.

"The benchmark for me is to get as much control on gun violence and violent offenders as humanly possible, getting them behind bars and getting them held, repeat

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FEELING ATTACKED AND DEFENSELESS

By Karina Atkins | Chicago Tribune

Shortly after George Floyd was murdered blocks from her home in Minneapolis, Mihesha Gibbs-Lumpkins decided to return to Pembroke Township with her husband and two children.

Her 13-year-old son was the one who voiced a need to escape the chaos. Walking to school, past the corner store where Floyd was suffocated by a police officer, was overwhelming.

"For this to happen so close to home and along his daily route it terrified us all," Gibbs-Lumpkins said.

Her hometown, a predominantly Black farming community 60 miles south of Chicago, was supposed to be the perfect reprieve.

Within a few months, the family of four moved into a quaint ramblar in Hopkins Park, a small village within the township. It was surrounded by rare black oak savanna and backed up to the landlocked area's unique sand dunes.

"Our way of life is not being respected. Our right just to sleep peacefully is not being respected. Hearing assault rifles for hours on end is gut-wrenching."

— Mihesha Gibbs-Lumpkins, a community engagement coordinator for the Nature Conservancy and a Hopkins Park village trustee

She recalled it as a place with no fences. One farm gave way to another, which gave way to an expanse of towering trees, which gave way to rolling hills of sand.

In the Pembroke she remembered, her kids would be able to play without boundaries. But she did not return to that Pembroke. Today, she doesn't feel comfortable letting her kids walk to the edge of her property alone.

Gibbs-Lumpkin and her neighbors feel that their once-tranquil community is slowly slipping away. Conservation groups began buying property in the early 2000s to create nature preserves. In the past decade, out-of-town

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INSIDE



JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Terrible, horrible, no good, very bad year

2024 was one of the worst in memory for Chicago sports. Here's one last look back at a lost year. **Paul Sullivan in Chicago Sports**

Discriminating based on source of income

The practice still is widespread despite new Illinois law, housing advocates say. Lawsuits may change that. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Who we lost from the arts world in 2024

Remembering the good times and grand talents, the pleasure and thrills that the lives of those who departed provided. **A+E**

Warsaw museum a symbol of openness

A new modern art museum — designed by an American — will help leave behind Poland's communist legacy. **Life+Travel**

WWII veteran's Purple Heart tracked down

Edward Gorski Jr. called 'a man's man' who was dedicated to his country and fellow soldiers

By Christy Gutowski
Chicago Tribune

In the final push to defeat Nazi Germany during World War II, Edward Gorski Jr. was trying to shield himself inside a foxhole in the city of Berlin when the 19-year-old Chicagoan was struck by enemy fire.

Gorski, a broad-shouldered Army private with a rugged face, was hit with mortar shrapnel after a fellow soldier in a nearby trench lit a fire for warmth, accidentally revealing their position to German forces.

It was May 2, 1945, days after



Edward Gorski in 1984.

Adolf Hitler's suicide and days before the end of the war in Europe. The shrapnel struck Gorski in the face, and he nearly lost an eye, but he survived to share some wartime stories — including how he earned a Purple Heart for his combat injuries.

"He said you'd see bullets flying, especially at night, and you'd hear them zip," said a son, Scott Gorski, 62, of North Carolina. "He told me as long as you hear them, you're fine. It's when you don't hear the bullet, that's

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World War II veteran Edward Gorski Jr., who died in 1993 of a heart attack, is buried at Elm Lawn Memorial Park in Elmhurst. Gorski survived being hit in the face by shrapnel in Germany during one of the final battles of the war. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

TODAY'S WEATHER



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Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 18

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